sanctioned sati and other practices. According to this Christian religious framework, all human souls have equal access to God and live to obey Him. Nevertheless, the devil and his priests corrupt this sense by imposing their fabrications as divinely revealed commandments upon innocent believers. In order to understand such people and go about with them, one should find out what they believe to be God's will for humanity. Which specific set of laws did the Hindus mistake for God's revelation? This was the obsession of early colonial scholars.[6]

….the toleration policy compelled colonial officials to determine which practices were truly religious and hence had to be tolerated. At this first level, Protestant notions of false religion operated implicitly. Even though the colonial government and its courts of law approached the Hindu traditions as religion tout court, without adding predicates of falsity, they nevertheless smuggled in the theological distinction between true religion as the revelation of God and false religion as human additions to religion. In fact, the Christian distinction between the religious, the secular, and the idolatrous was introduced as though it concerned a distinction internal to Hindu religion. Some practices were accepted as truly religious, while others were rejected as illegitimate additions to religion.

The boundary was drawn along the lines of the Protestant division between the essentials commanded by God in scripture and indifferent things falsely superimposed as religion… . In its secularized form, this division between pure religion and human additions was viewed as a general characteristic of all religions, including Hinduism. Since the task of locating this boundary was displaced to the 'scriptures' and 'priests' of 'Hindu religion', the colonial legal system effectively transplanted this conceptual structure into the Hindu traditions.

Consequently, the normative framework behind the colonial legal system compelled Hindu traditions to internalize the Christian division between the religious, the secular and the falsely religious… . All aspects of Indian traditions that did not fit into the codified model of Hindu law were rejected as illegitimate human additions to true 'Hindu religion' or denounced as ceremonies and rites that had no role to play in genuine 'Hindu law'. Thus, these aspects were relegated to a hidden realm of false religion.[7]